

Loons

PHYLUM	Chordata
CLASS	Aves
ORDER	Gaviiformes
FAMILIES	1 (Gaviidae)
SPECIES	6

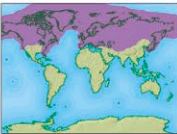
Also known as divers, loons are superbly adapted for underwater swimming. With their streamlined bodies, legs set far back on the body for efficient propulsion, and strong, webbed feet, they can reach depths of 250 ft (75 m) and stay underwater for several minutes. Dense plumage insulates them in the Arctic and sub-Arctic waters where they live. Despite having small, pointed wings and a pinlike tail, loons fly well. But with feet set so far back, they are almost incapable of walking on land.



PLUMAGE
Loons spend a lot of time taking care of their feathers and can often be seen rolling on their side to reach their belly feathers. A varied breeding plumage (seen here in the Pacific loon) is replaced by simpler, less colorful patterns in winter.

Gavia stellata

Red-throated loon



Length 22–28 in (55–70 cm)
Weight 2¼–5½ lb (1–2.5 kg)
Plumage Sexes alike
Migration Migrant
Status Least concern

Location North America, Greenland, Europe, Asia



Distinguished from other loons by the reddish brown throat patch at the base of its thick, long neck, this bird has a plump, oval body that is dark grayish to black with white spots; the underparts are whitish. An inhabitant of coastal bays and inlets, it moves inland to lakes

and marshes in northern forests and Arctic tundra during the breeding season, where it emits a loud yodel or wail to attract a mate or establish territory. Courtship behavior involves splashing dives, dipping and shaking of bills, and rushing across the water in pairs. Nests are usually a simple platform of reed, rushes, and grass.



Gavia immer

Common loon



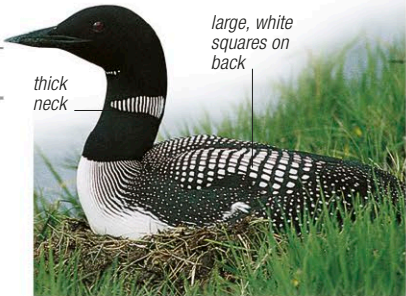
Length 28–35 in (70–90 cm)
Weight 6½–10 lb (3–4.5 kg)
Plumage Sexes alike
Migration Migrant
Status Least concern

Location North America, Greenland, W. Europe



This gray to black and white bird is usually solitary or found in pairs, although large groups of up to 300 may be seen feeding along the coast when not breeding. Like other loons, this species can dive to great depths when hunting for fish and aquatic

invertebrates, which it seizes with its bill, sometimes spearing them. It may also dive to avoid predators such as mammals, hawks, and eagles. Both sexes care for the young, and the chicks stay with their parents until fledged, at about 10–11 weeks. Parents sometimes swim with the young on their backs.



Grebes

PHYLUM	Chordata
CLASS	Aves
ORDER	Podicipediformes
FAMILIES	1 (Podicipedidae)
SPECIES	23

Found in sheltered waters throughout the world, grebes are strong swimmers and accomplished divers. They are ideally suited to aquatic life: their small head and thin neck enable them to dive easily when hunting for food, and their feet—which are set well back on the body—have lobed

toes with highly flexible joints that give these birds great agility when swimming. Their soft, dense plumage is very water-resistant. Grebes are remarkable for their often elaborate courtship rituals.



“WEED DANCE”
During the “weed dance,” a courting pair (here, great crested grebes) dive for vegetation, then rise out of the water to face each other, holding the plants up high.

Tachybaptus ruficollis

Little grebe

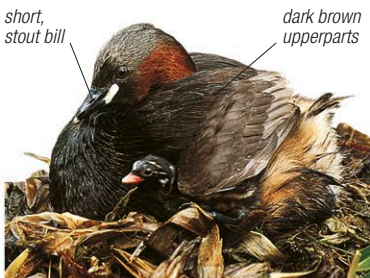


Length 10–11½ in (25–29 cm)
Weight 4–8 oz (125–225 g)
Plumage Sexes alike
Migration Partial migrant
Status Least concern

Location Europe, Asia, Africa, Madagascar, New Guinea

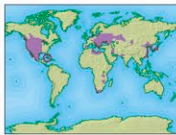


The smallest grebe in Europe and northern Asia, this short-billed bird is brown with a bright chestnut throat and cheeks. It stands and walks on land more easily than other grebes, and is also more likely to fly outside of migration. Both sexes build nests of aquatic vegetation, anchoring them to surface water plants or branches of bushes growing in water.



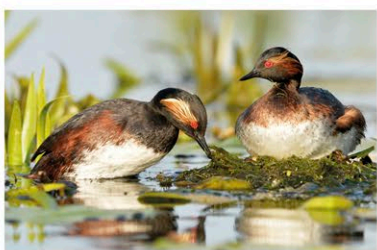
Podiceps nigricollis

Black-necked grebe



Length 12–14 in (30–35 cm)
Weight 9–21 oz (250–600 g)
Plumage Sexes alike
Migration Migrant
Status Least concern

Location North America, Europe, Asia, N. and southern Africa



This small, dark grebe (non-breeding plumage shown), with a slender, slightly upturned bill, is highly social all year. During the non-breeding season, it prefers saline waters, with thousands gathering on some saltwater lakes. However, it breeds in freshwater lakes and marshes, where it makes floating nests. Adults carry young on their backs for the first few weeks, but little parental care is required after 3 weeks.